



The Scary Truth About Labels

2021 // Dennie Declercq // Tech A11y Summit



Who am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- Passionate Developer
- President & IT-coach DDSOft
- Microsoft MVP
- #DreamingIsBelieving



(or) Who Am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- Autistic
- Jobless
- Volunteer
- Man
- Single
- Not a graduate



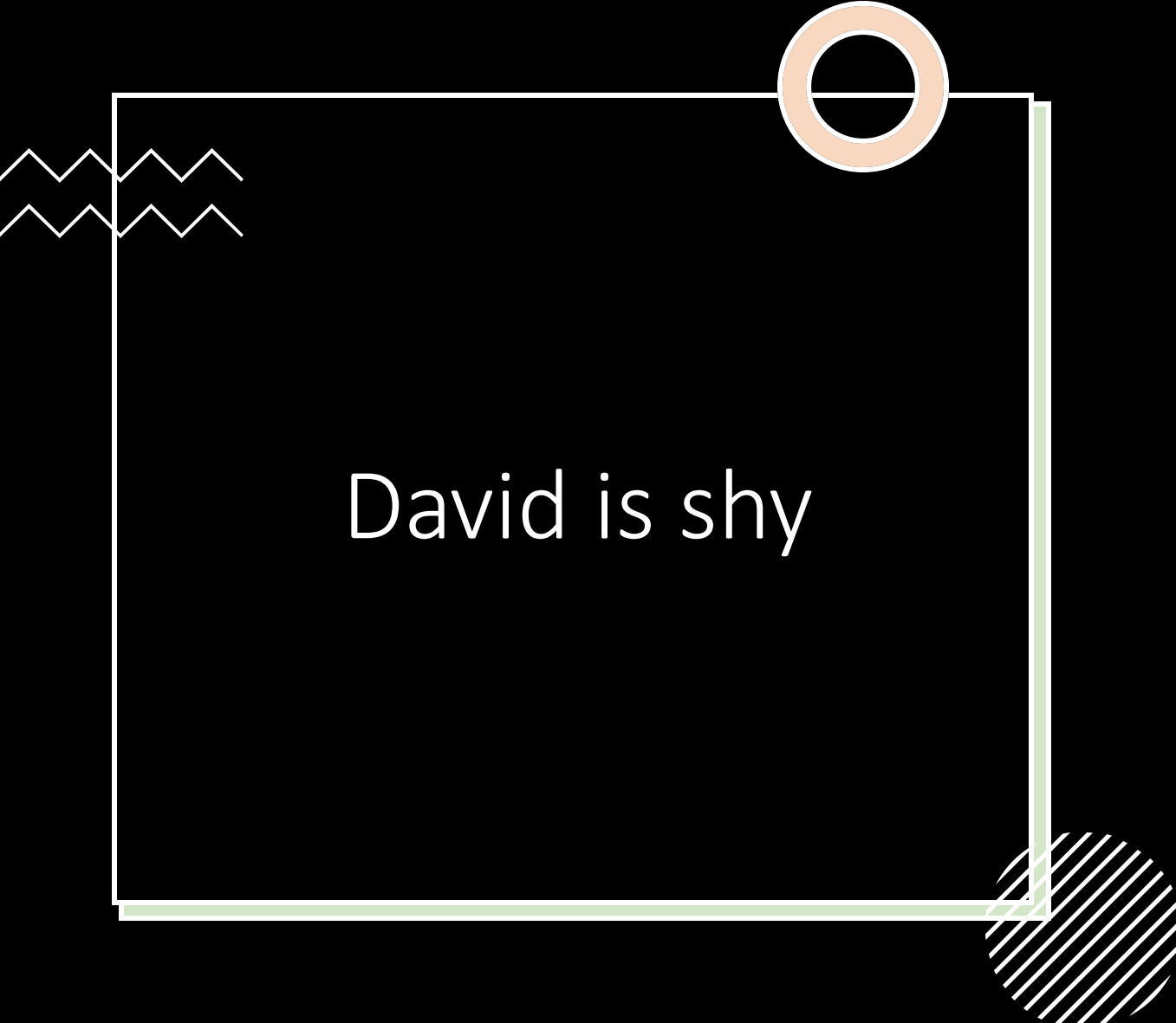
Who Am I? Revisited

- Dennie
- A person
- A unique living being

What can
Lisa do vs
what can't
she do?

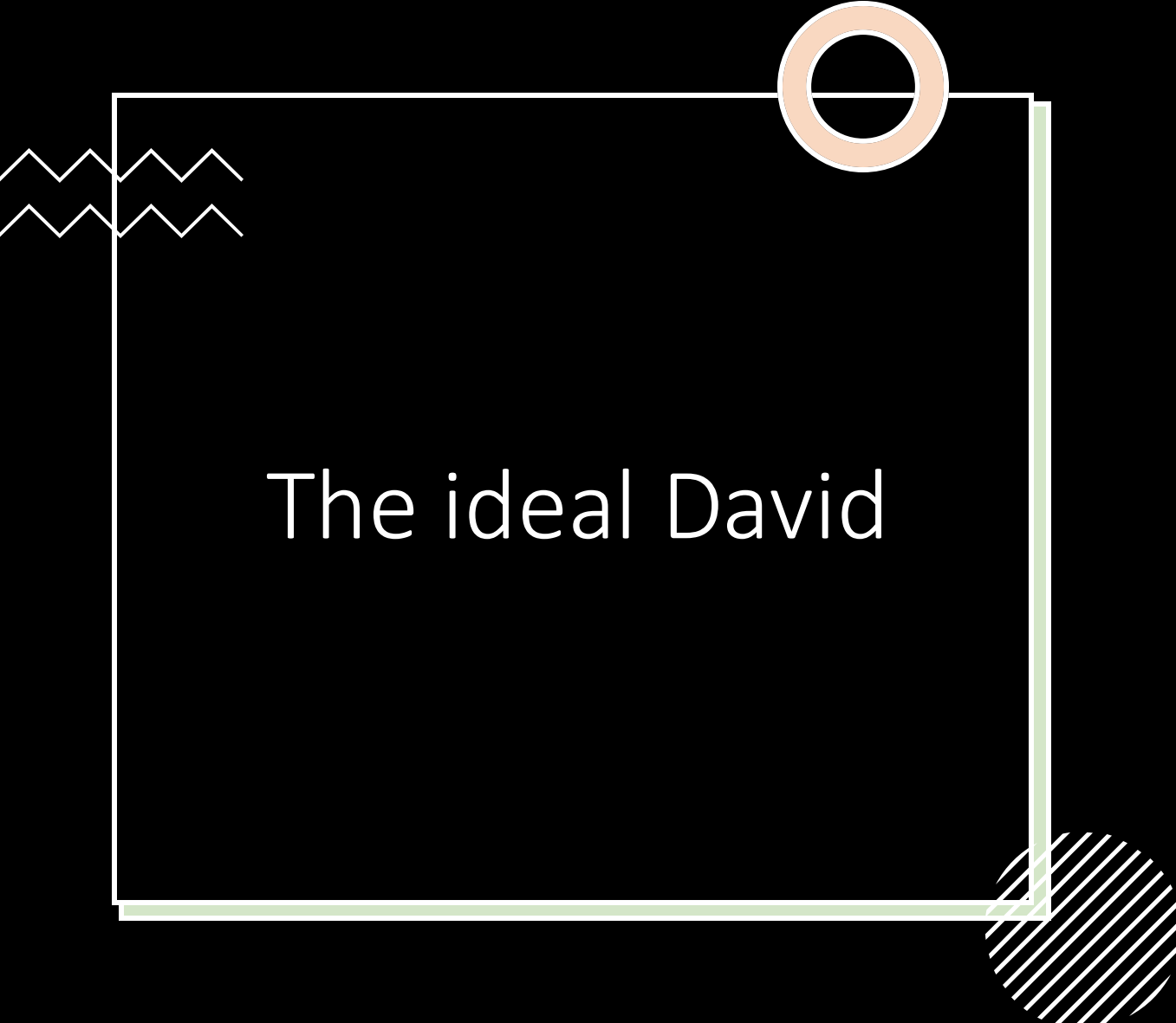
- She's not masculine
- She is not a graduate
- What are opportunities didn't she had
- She's not a math engineer

- She is clever
- She is self-thought
- Lisa has unique views
- Lisa is unique
- Lisa found a way to program in C++
 - With a self-made work around math



David is shy

- He need to do a job
 - In a factory
 - In a group
 - He doesn't belong
 - He is bullied for being weird
- In his free time
 - He draws the nicest drawings
 - He can't sell them
 - He throws them away
- He is not allowed to sell this, because he couldn't start a business



The ideal David

- Sells his drawings
- Focussed full day on drawings
- People, fabrics, bars, hotels, streets
 - Enlightened with David's talent



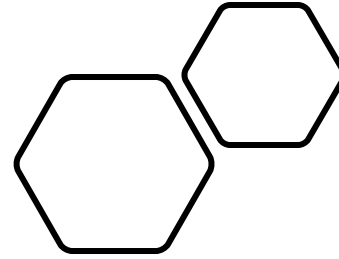
Label: Normal

- Can do everything
- Lives healthy
- Eats healthy
- Indicates borders and limits
 - But goes a lot over own borders
- Has well-paid job
- Has 2 kids: a boy and a girl
- Has a hobby

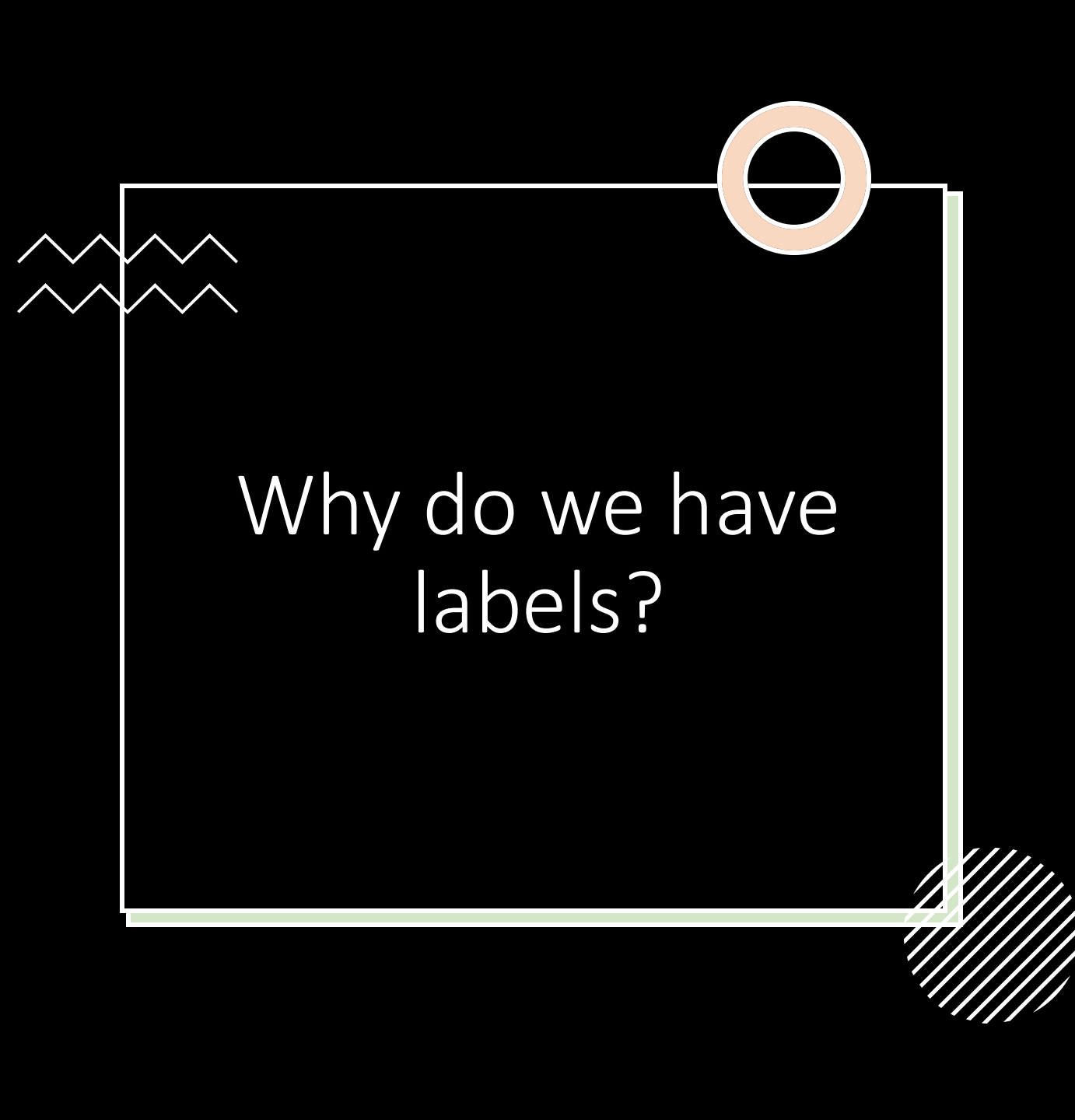


How many people do
you know?

How many
people don't
dare to talk
about



Their differences



Why do we have
labels?

- Legacy
- Grouping of people
- Budgets are based on groups
- Funds are based on groups
- Regulations are based on groups



We de-individualised
people

- But put them in labels and regions



Life is based on the major
...%

And compare others with a less vision.

Labels exclude other labels

OR

- Man
- Left-handed
- 'paid' job
- Tech-savy
- Engineer
- Smart
- Geek

OR

- Woman
- Right-handed
- Jobless
- (complete) Tech noob
- Spiritual
- Dumb
- Social

We need to make choices

OR

- Eating healthy
- Sitting job
- Being rich
- Study

OR

- Eating tasty
- Standing job
- Working (less/ not paid)
- Starting young helping the family

We learned

To sacrifice

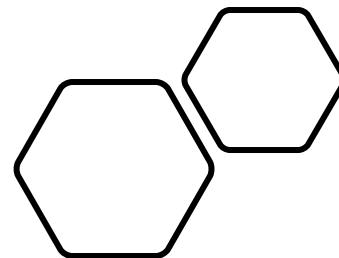
If we belong to a label

- We need to live completely as 'on the label'

The label 'normal' is the label to go for

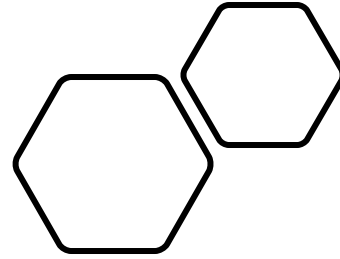
We need to make trade-offs

We identify



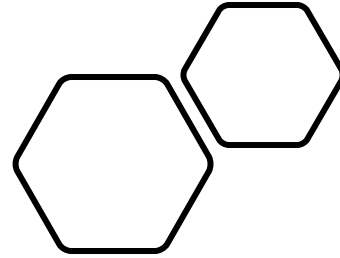
Or do we get identified?

Think outside the box



- Think thru the labels
- Think and-and instead of or-or
- Being whole (my friend Dux Raymond Sy @meetdux)

Boxes? Labels?



- A coder with a spiritual passion
- A famous cook who is vegetarian (but cooking meat for customers)
- A girl clothed as a man
- A coder with a lack of math
- An MVP without a job



Time

- Working
 - 80% - 20%
 - Day – Night
 - 90% - 10%
- What is time?



Talking about D&I is just
the beginning

It need to become the new normal



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